THE DECISION THAT CHANGED EVERYTHING

When Daniel was offered a promotion, he expected to feel excited. Instead, he felt strangely uncomfortable. For years, he had worked hard to build his career, and becoming a manager seemed like the obvious next step. However, the position came with a lot more responsibility, and Daniel wasn't sure whether he was ready for it.

His manager, Sarah, noticed his hesitation.

"You've been working toward this for years," she said. "Why are you having second thoughts?"

Daniel (1) _____ for a moment before answering.

"I don't know. I suppose I'm afraid I'll make mistakes. As a team member, I only have to worry about my own work. As a manager, I'll be responsible for other people's performance too."

Sarah smiled. "That's completely normal. Leadership isn't about knowing everything. It's about being willing to learn."

Daniel appreciated her advice, but he still couldn't (2) _____ the feeling that he might fail.

That evening, he discussed the situation with his friend Mark. Mark listened carefully and then said, "You know what your problem is? You're focusing too much on everything that could go wrong."

"Isn't that sensible?" Daniel asked.

"Not always. Sometimes you have to (3) _____ and take a chance. If you spend your entire life trying to avoid failure, you'll never know what you're capable of."

Daniel knew Mark had a point. He had always been (4) _____ of taking risks. He preferred situations where he knew exactly what to expect.

The next morning, Daniel decided to accept the promotion.

His first few weeks were difficult. One of his team members regularly missed deadlines, while another constantly disagreed with his decisions. Daniel quickly realized that managing people was completely different from managing tasks.

At first, he tried to solve every problem himself. Eventually, however, he understood that he couldn't (5) _____ everything alone. He needed to trust his team and give them more responsibility.

One afternoon, a major client complained about a mistake made by Daniel's team. Daniel was furious. His first reaction was to blame the employee responsible.

But then he (6) _____ and thought about the situation carefully. The mistake wasn't entirely the employee's fault. Daniel had never clearly explained the procedure in the first place.

Instead of criticizing his employee, Daniel admitted his own mistake.

To his surprise, the employee respected him more because of it.

Over the following months, Daniel became a better leader. He learned to communicate clearly, listen to different opinions, and (7) _____ when problems appeared instead of ignoring them.

He also learned an important lesson: confidence doesn't always come before action.

Sometimes, you have to take action first, make mistakes, learn from them, and gradually become confident.

A year later, Daniel looked back at his first day as a manager and smiled. He realized that accepting the promotion had (8) _____.

He hadn't become a perfect manager. In fact, he still made mistakes. But he was no longer afraid of them.

He had finally learned that growth often begins when we (9) _____.

ANSWER KEYS

paused — stopped briefly before doing/saying something | shake off — get rid of a feeling, thought, or problem | take the plunge — finally decide to do something difficult or risky | wary — cautious because you are aware of possible problems or danger | handle — deal with or manage something
took a step back — stopped and considered a situation more calmly/objectively | tackle problems head-on — deal with problems directly rather than avoiding them | paid off — produced a good result after effort or difficulty | step outside our comfort zone — do something unfamiliar or challenging

1. **Have you ever had to take the plunge and make a difficult decision?**
2. **Are you generally comfortable stepping outside your comfort zone? Why or why not?**
3. **How do you usually handle problems when you're under pressure?**
4. **Do you think making mistakes is necessary for personal growth?**
5. **What is something you've done recently that eventually paid off?**